Getting Ready to Ask the Medicaid Question

An ordered plan for your family's part: eleven actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: you can hand a professional a written picture of Mom's care, her income and what she owns, her home, and any gifts or transfers, with what's on paper, what's from memory and what's missing each marked as such.

Share the list. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Write down what you've been told about Medicaid so far, such as “too much money” or “spend down,” and who said each thing.			
2. Write down the state Mom lives in, where she is getting care and what kind of care it is. Ask the facility's social worker or business office which Medicaid program goes with that kind of care.			
3. Gather the papers you have that show where Mom lives and her citizenship or immigration status.			
4. Ask for a copy of what the hospital, the rehab or the facility has written about the care Mom needs.			
5. Bring out your list of Mom's income and what she owns. Mark each line “on paper” or “from memory.” Don't total it, and don't sort it into what counts and what doesn't.			
6. Write down whether Mom is married and, if she is, where her spouse is living.			
7. Beside the home and each account, write whose name is on it, as the paperwork shows, including anything owned with someone else.			
8. List any gifts, transfers or changes in ownership anyone remembers, with rough dates and who was involved. Note them and change nothing.			
9. Gather the trust documents, annuity contracts and life insurance policies, if there are any.			
10. List what's missing: each paper you couldn't find and each fact nobody is sure of.			
11. Next to each open question, write who it goes to: the family, the facility's business office, the Medicaid agency, your Medicaid planner, or “not sure.”			

You're done when

What you know about Mom's care, her income and what she owns, her home, her spouse and any gifts or transfers is written down, with each line marked as on paper or from memory. What's missing is listed, and every open question has a name beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list: reviewing all of it against the rules in Mom's state, and saying where she stands and what may need attention before applying. That is your Medicaid planner's part, with an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional where one is needed, and it isn't the family's to do alone.

If something won't turn up

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If two people remember a gift or a transfer differently, write both versions with a name beside each.
- If someone offers a new opinion about whether Mom qualifies, add it to the list from action 1 with their name. It's one more thing to confirm.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't determine whether Mom is eligible, compare anything with a limit, recommend a legal or financial strategy, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for. Medicaid rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

Your family's part is on paper, and every open question has a name beside it. The planning interview is the next step: answer its questions about your family's situation and it gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

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